umbrella or a wheel representing their respective dharmas. As mentioned earlier, both faiths sought to make their teachings more accessible by incorporating elements of folk-worship as protectors and attendants in the form of statues of *yaksha*s and *yakshi*s (nature-spirits), and such celestial creatures as *apsara*s and *gandharva*s, drawing on existing local traditions of ivory-carving and modelling in clay fired into terracotta.

One particular goddess now began to emerge as the first clearly identifiable female deity to appear in Indian art. She is habitually described as the goddess Lakshmi but it would be more accurate to describe her as the rice-providing deity Shri, who has claims to be a genuinely Vedic divinity, rising out of the first churning of the milk-ocean as radiant light to make her mark in the *Atharva-Veda*. She is always shown being lustrated by two elephants while seated or standing on a lotus, which the Buddhists first sought to claim for themselves as the symbol of Buddhist dharma, so her first appearance in Indian art is as a bringer of good fortune to the followers of Buddhism (see illustrations overleaf).[15]

One known early centre of ivory-carving was the town of Vidisha, close to Sanchi hill, and it may well have been here that the exquisite statuette misleadingly called the ‘Pompeii Lakshmi’ was carved. This was found in a charred wooden chest disinterred from the volcanic ash of Pompeii in 1939 and took the form of a *yakshi* fertility goddess just under 10 inches in height (25 centimetres). She is clad in nothing more than bangles, beads and garlands, and – as almost invariably in portrayals of Indian women from the very earliest times – has elaborately coiffed hair which she is engaged in adjusting. As with the earliest stone *yakshi*s, this dainty little goddess, most likely fashioned in about the first century BCE, is overtly sexual in the unashamed way she displays herself. A very similar ivory figurine was recently found at Ter in central Maharashtra, known to the Romans